Medea

By Christopher Durang and Wendy Wasserstein

The actress who is to play Medea comes out and makes the following introduction.

ACTRESS: Hello. I am she who will be Medea. That is, I shall play the heroine from that famous Greek tragedy by Euripides for you. I attended a first rate School of Dramatic Arts. At this wonderful school, I had classical training, which means we start at the very beginning, a very good place to start. Greek tragedy.

As an actress who studied the classics, one of the first things you learn in drama school is that there are more roles for men than for women. This is a wonderful thing to learn because it is true of the real world as well. Except for *Thelma and Louise.* At drama school, in order to compensate for this problem, the women every year got to act in either *The Trojan Women* or *The House of Bernardo Alba.* This prepared us for bit parts on *Designing Women* and *Little House on the Prairie.* Although these shows are cancelled now, and we have nothing to do.

I would like to present to you a selection from one of the most famous Greek tragedies ever written, *The Trojan Women,* translated from the Greek by George Stephanoulous, here is a scene from this terrifying tragedy.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

Medea by Christopher Durang and Wendy Wasserstein

Enter the Chorus. In the style of the piece, they are over-dramatic and over-wrought. But most of the time they should act their lines as if they are the words from genuine Greek tragedy, full of intonation and emotional feeling. Don't send them up, or wink at the audience. Let the juxtaposition of Greek tragedy acting style and the sometimes silly lines be what creates the humor.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* So pitiful, so pitiful
your shame and lamentation.
No more shall I move the shifting pace of the shuttle at the looms of Ida. - *(Echoes.)* Looms of Ida.
Can you not, Queen Hecuba, stop this Bacchanal before her light feet whirl her away into the Argive camp? *(Echoes.)* Argive camp.
O woe, O woe, O woe,
So pitiful, so wretched, so doomed, Women who run with wolves
Women who love too much,
Whitewater rapids, how did she turn $1000 into $100,000?
O woe, O woe, O woe,
Here she comes now.
Wooga, wooga, wooga.

(Enter Medea in a dramatic, blood red toga. She is in high, excessive grief and fury.)

MEDEA: Come, flame of the sky, Pierce through my head!
What do I, Medea, gain from living any longer? Oh I hate living! I want
to end my life, leave it behind, and die.

CHORUS: *(In unison; chanted seriously.)* But tell us how you're really feeling.

MEDEA: My husband Jason - the Argonaut - has left me for another woman.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Debbie.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* Dreaded Debbie, dreaded Debbie. Debutante from hell.

MEDEA: She is the daughter of King Creon, who owns a diner on 55th Street and Jamaica Avenue. Fie on her! And the House of Creon! And the four brothers of the Acropolis. I am banished from my husband's bed, and from the country. A bad predicament all around. But I am skilled in poison. Today three of my enemies I will strike down dead: Debbie and Debbie's father and my husband.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* Speaking of your husband, here he comes.

(Enter Jason, dressed in a toga, but also with an armored breast plate and wearing a soldier's helmet with a nice little red adornment on top. Sort of like a costume from either Ben Hur *or* Cleopatra. *He perhaps is not in the grand style, but sounds more normal and conversational.)*

JASON: Hello, Medea.

MEDEA: Hello, Jason.

JASON: I hear you've been banished to China.

MEDEA: *(Suddenly Noel Coward brittle.)* Very large, China.

JASON: And Japan?

MEDEA: Very small, Japan. And Debbie?

JASON: She's very striking.

MEDEA: Some women should be struck regularly like gongs.

JASON: Medea, even though thou art banished by Creon to foreign shores, the two innocent children of our loins, Lyle and Erik, should remain with me. I will enroll them at the Dalton School. And there will they will flourish as citizens of Corinth under the watchful eye of Zeus and his lovely and talented wife Hera.

MEDEA: Fine, walk on me some more! I was born unlucky and a woman.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* Men are from Mars, women are from Venus.

JASON: Well, whatever. I call the gods to witness that I have done my best to help you and the children.

MEDEA: Go! You have spent too long out here. You are consumed with craving for your newly-won bride, Debbie. Go, enjoy Debbie! *(Jason shrugs, exits.)* O, woe, O, woe. I am in pain for I know what I must do. Debbie, kill for sure.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* Debbie's done, ding dong, Debbie's done. Done deal, Debbie dead. Dopey Debbie, Debbie dead.

MEDEA: But also my sons. Never shall their father see them again. I shall kill my children. *(Ferociously, to the Chorus.)* How do you like that????

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* Aaaaaaagghghghghghghgghhhhh! A smart women, foolish choices. Stop the insanity! Stop the insanity!
You can eat one slice of cheese, or 16 baked potatoes! Make up your mind.

MEDEA: Why is there so little *Trojan Women* in this, and so much of me?

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* We don't know *The Trojan Women* as well as we know *Medea.* *(Spoken, not sung.)*
Medea, we just met a girl named Medea. And suddenly that name
Will never be the same.

MEDEA: Bring my children hither.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* O, miserable mother, to destroy your own increase, murder the babes of your body. The number you have reached is not in service at this time. Call 777-FILM.

MEDEA: *(In a boiling fury.)* I want to kill my children. I want to sleep with my brother. I want to pluck out the eyes of my father. I want to blow up the Parthenon. I need a creative outlet for all this anger. *(Enter the*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Messenger, carrying a head. He kneels before Medea.)

MESSENGER: I am a messenger. Caesar is dead.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* Caesar is dead. How interesting. Who is Caesar?

MESSENGER: I am sorry. Wrong message. *(Reads from piece of paper.)* Lady Teazle wishes you to know that Lady Windermere and Lady Bracknell are inviting you and Lady The-Scottish-Play to tea with her cousin Ernest, if he's not visiting Mr. Bunberry.

MEDEA: Mr. Bunberry? I do not need a messenger. I need a deus ex machina. *(Elaborate music. Enter an Angel with great big wings. Descending from the ceiling,* or *revealed on a balcony.* Or *dragging a step ladder that he stands on. Very dramatic whatever he does.)*

ANGEL: O, Medea, O, Medea.

I am a deus ex machina.

In a bigger production, I would come down from the sky in an angel's outfit, but just use your imagination. Theatre is greatly about imagination, is it not.

I am an angel.

I I I I I I I, yi yi yi.

I I I I am the Bird of Greek Tragedy.

Do not kill your children. Do not sleep with your brother.

Rein in your rage, and thank Zeus. I come with glad tidings. Debbie is no more a threat. She's been cast in a series. She has a running part on *Home Improvements.*

CHORUS: *(In unison.) Home Improvements.*

ANGEL: Jason will return to you. He sees the error of his ways. He has been lobotomized.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* O fortunate woman, to whom Zeus has awarded a docile husband.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MEDEA: O, deus ex machina, O, angel: O, Hecuba, oh, looms of Ida.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* Ida Ida Ida Ida.

MEDEA: I am eternally grateful to you.

CHORUS: *(In unison.)* The things we thought would happen do not happen. The unexpected, God makes possible.

(Spoken, not sung.)

The camptown races sing a song, Do da, do da.

CHORUS and MEDEA: *(Switch to singing now.)* Medea's happy the whole day long,

Oh the do da day!

Things will be just fine,

Things will be just great

No need to kill her children now, Oh the do da ...

(Big musical coda:)

Oh the do da, Zeus and Buddha, They're as nice as Dionysus,

Oh the do da Work it though da

Oh the do da, do da, do da Day!

(Medea and the Chorus and the Angel strike a happy and triumphant pose.)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Christopher Durang and Wendy Wasserstein
Book: 27 Short Plays
ISBN: 978-1880399897
Publisher: Smith and Kraus Publishers
Date (Month/Year): Feb 1996

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier - HI
2008 National Qualifier – HI